Lesson 47: Strong Words, Active Voice and Concision

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 6.5 Using Strong and Specific Words; 6.7 Using Active Voice; 6.8 Avoiding Wordiness.

In this lesson

You will practice three strategies for clear sentences: choosing strong, specific words; using active voice where it is appropriate; and cutting wordy phrases. You will advise the student writer Amanda Wu on her draft about food deserts (Lesson 46) and then revise a paragraph yourself. These strategies make research writing, including descriptions of psychology studies, shorter, clearer and more lively.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Replace general words and weak verbs (get, make, have, do) with strong, specific ones.
- Identify passive voice and rewrite it in active voice.
- Decide when passive voice is acceptable, for example in the methods section of a research report.
- Find and cut wordy expressions such as "there is", "due to the fact that" and "in order to".

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
specific (adj)	exact, with a precise meaning (opposite: general)	Instead of "things," tell your reader what the "things" are.
weak verb	a general verb such as be, do, get, make or have	The committee made a decision to revise the community guidelines.
strong verb	a verb with a specific meaning that carries the action	The committee decided to revise the community guidelines.
active voice	the subject does the action	Regulators require documentation of pesticide use.
passive voice	be + past participle: the receiver of the action is the subject	Documentation of pesticide use is required by regulators.
scrutinize (v)	examine closely and carefully	Environmental regulators have scrutinized the strawberry industry.
wordiness (n)	using more words than you need	Eliminating wordiness helps all readers because it makes your ideas clear, direct, and straightforward.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
empty phrase	an expression that adds little meaning	these days, in terms of, due to the fact that, on the subject of, more or less
methods section	the part of a research paper that describes how the study was done	Writers usually use passive voice in the methods section of research papers.
control group / placebo	the group in an experiment that does not receive the real treatment / a "treatment" with no active effect	Patients in the control group were given a saline solution placebo.

Rules and explanations

Strong and specific words

- **Each word counts.** Choose words with specific meanings. Instead of "things," or even "vegetables," name and describe them (for example, the colorful bell peppers in the book's photo of a farmers market).
- **Strong verbs.** A noun with a weak verb (be, do, make) slows the sentence down and adds words: *made a decision → decided*. The strong verb gives the same meaning with fewer words and more lively action.
- Depending on your meaning, try these stronger verbs from the book:

Instead of	try
get	obtain, understand, fetch, receive, attain
make	cause, require, produce, create, construct
have (as a main verb)	possess, experience, keep, own, exhibit
do (as a main verb)	attempt, complete, finish, achieve, participate in, contribute to

Active and passive voice

- **Active:** the subject does the action. *Over the past several years, environmental regulators have scrutinized the strawberry industry.*
- **Passive:** the grammatical object (the strawberry industry) moves to the subject position, and the doer comes at the end with by, or disappears. *The strawberry industry has been scrutinized over the past several years.*
- To find passive voice, look for a form of **be + past participle** (has been scrutinized, is required). The book describes the participle as the "-ed" form; irregular participles count too (was given, is sold).
- To revise, ask who or what does the action in each clause, and make that the subject: *Documentation of pesticide use is required by regulators. → Regulators require documentation of pesticide use.*

- Active voice usually makes writing clearer, livelier and less wordy.

When is passive voice acceptable?

When you want to focus on **what** was done, not **who** did it, and the meaning stays clear. Writers usually use passive voice in the methods section of research papers and in lab reports:

- *The compound was heated to 75 degrees Celsius.*
- *Patients in the control group were given a saline solution placebo.*
- *Respondents who agreed were contacted with follow-up questions.*

In other sections and in most writing, use active voice if possible.

In psychology (APA style): APA style prefers active voice even in methods sections ("We randomly assigned participants to two groups"), but accepts passive when the person who did the action does not matter ("Participants were randomly assigned to two groups").

Avoiding wordiness

Type	Wordy	Revised (the book's examples)
"There is / There are" openings	There is an abundance of agriculture in California.	Agriculture is abundant in California.
empty phrases (these days, in terms of, due to the fact that, on the subject of, more or less)	These days, food deserts exist in many parts of the state; ... people do not have access to fresh, affordable foods due to a variety of reasons.	Food deserts exist in many parts of the state; ... people do not have access to fresh, affordable foods for a variety of reasons.
constructions that sound important but are empty	In order to combat skepticism about phenomena such as gentrification, it's absolutely essential that community members are invited to be involved in opening new supermarkets in their own communities.	To combat skepticism about gentrification, it's essential that community members be involved in opening new supermarkets in their own communities.

Common short replacements: in order to → to; due to the fact that → because; on the subject of → about; absolutely essential → essential.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Formal Arabic often uses a general verb + verbal noun (literally "carried out a visit", "made a decision"). Translated word for word, this gives wordy English with weak verbs. Use the strong verb: visited, decided. - Arabic news style often says that something "was completed" (the signing of the agreement was completed). In English, name the doer: the two governments signed the agreement.

Practice

Exercise 1: Strong verbs. Replace the weak verb in bold with a stronger verb from the table. More than one answer may be possible.

1. The community garden's committee **made a decision** to revise the community guidelines.
2. It's tough for people of lower socioeconomic status to **get** healthy food because they cannot afford high-end organic food.
3. As specified by FARA, 33% of residents in West Oakland are at least one mile away from any supermarket, and one-third of its residents do not **have** vehicles.
4. Thus, they cannot sell many types of fresh produce because they do not **have** refrigerators to keep the produces fresh.

Exercise 2: Strong and specific words in a paragraph. Read the paragraph from Amanda's essay in section 6.5 of the lesson material (it begins "It's tough for people of lower socioeconomic status to get healthy food"). (a) What are some effective word choices she has made? (b) Find five places where her word choice could be improved, and suggest better words. (The book calls this "the second paragraph"; it is the third paragraph of the full draft. The book also calls the writer "Alicia" once; it means Amanda.)

Exercise 3: Identifying active vs. passive voice. These three sentences are all grammatically correct. Which one gets the idea across most clearly and accurately? Why?

1. The same pesticides that eliminate destructive insects also kill the bees we depend on to pollinate food crops.
2. Destructive insects are eliminated by pesticides, but the bees we depend on to pollinate food crops are also killed by the application of these chemicals.
3. Destructive insects are eliminated, but the bees we depend on to pollinate food crops are also killed.

Exercise 4: Identifying passive voice in a paragraph. Read the paragraph from Amanda's essay in section 6.7 of the lesson material (it begins "It's difficult for people of lower socioeconomic status"). Find three sentences that use passive voice when active voice would be more effective (some sentences use it more than once). Rewrite them in active voice.

Exercise 5: Identifying wordiness. Read the introduction to Amanda's essay in section 6.8 of the lesson material. (a) What are its strengths? (b) Find five wordy phrases or sentences and rewrite them more succinctly.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my revision of paragraph 4 of Amanda's draft: [paste]. Compare it with the original. Is it shorter and clearer? Did I change the meaning anywhere?"
- "Give me ten wordy or passive sentences about psychology research, one at a time. I will make each one concise and active. Tell me if my version is better, and when the passive should stay."
- "Here is my description of a study: [paste]. Which passive sentences should stay passive, and which should become active?"
- "Quiz me: give me sentences with get, make, have or do, and I will replace the verb with a stronger, more specific one."

Read aloud

Pause at each |.

1. The community garden's committee decided | to revise the community guidelines.
2. Over the past several years, | environmental regulators have scrutinized the strawberry industry.
3. The same pesticides that eliminate destructive insects | also kill the bees we depend on | to pollinate food crops.
4. Patients in the control group | were given a saline solution placebo.
5. Agriculture is abundant in California.
6. To combat skepticism about gentrification, | it's essential that community members be involved | in opening new supermarkets in their own communities.

Writing task

Revise a paragraph of 150-250 words for strong words, active voice and concision. Choose one:

- paragraph 4 (corner liquor stores) or paragraph 5 (food hubs and community gardens) of Amanda's draft, keeping her meaning and her sources;
- a paragraph you wrote in Lessons 42-46;
- a psychology option: describe one of the studies in "Untrustworthy Memories Make it Hard to Shop Ethically" (Lesson 42) as in the methods and results of a report: who took part, what they did, what the researchers found. Use active voice for the researchers' actions and passive only where the doer does not matter.

After the paragraph, list five changes you made and the reason for each.

Checklist:

- Did you replace general words (things, good) with specific ones?
- Did you replace noun + weak verb (made a decision) with a strong verb (decided)?
- Did you check every be + past participle and ask who does the action?
- Did you keep the passive only where the doer is unknown or unimportant?
- Did you cut "There is / There are" openings where possible?
- Did you cut empty phrases (due to the fact that, in order to, these days, absolutely)?
- Did you keep the original meaning and every source citation?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1.

1. decided (book)
2. obtain (also correct: buy, purchase)
3. own (also correct: possess)
4. own or possess (also correct: because they lack refrigerators). Note also: produce is non-count here, so "keep the produce fresh", not "produces".

Exercise 2. (example answer) (a) Specific numbers (median family income of $35,037 in West Oakland and $70,850 in the U.S.; organic butter at $5.29 and non-organic at $3.49) and precise academic words (median family income, socioeconomic status, conventional food, self-sufficient, purchase). ("Manual labor" and "determinative barrier" are also precise, but they are inside her quotations, so they are her sources' words.) (b) Any five of these:

- "It's tough" (informal) → It is difficult
- "get healthy food" (weak verb) → obtain / buy healthy food
- "organic food has no chemical fertilizers or pesticides" (weak verb have) → organic food is grown without chemical fertilizers or pesticides
- "its price is higher than conventional food" → organic food costs more than conventional food
- "as reported by an article" (general and passive) → as Psaltopoulou and colleagues report
- "much less purchasing good food" (general word good) → much less purchasing fresh, healthy food

Exercise 3. (book) Sentence 1 is best because it is in active voice: it focuses on the subject (pesticides) doing actions (eliminating, killing) to objects (destructive insects, bees). Sentence 2 is in passive voice: it gives the same information, but it focuses on the objects and adds the subject (pesticides) as if it were extra information; it is not wrong, but it is less clear. Sentence 3 is in passive voice and does not name the subject (pesticides) at all.

Exercise 4. (book; revision 3 corrected)

1. ...because not enough fresh produce is sold by stores in their communities. → ...because not enough stores in their communities sell fresh produce.
2. ...and vehicles are not owned by one-third of its residents. → ...and one-third of its residents do not own vehicles.
3. ...it can reasonably be assumed that if people don't have a car and taking the bus is needed..., their willingness to purchase healthy food will be diminished. → Given the facts above, one can reasonably assume that if people don't have a car and need to take the bus to the market, they will be less willing to purchase healthy food. (The book's key says "it can reasonably be assumed"; this is a mistake because that phrase is still passive voice. Amanda's draft has the active "one can reasonably assume"; "we can reasonably assume" is also correct.)

Other passive forms in the paragraph can stay: "is based on" (a common fixed expression), "published" and "As specified by" (short participle phrases), and "is considered" (inside a quotation, which you

cannot change).

Exercise 5. (example answer) (a) The questions hook the reader; the sources come with their authors' credentials; the income figure is specific; the term food desert is defined; the last sentence states the paper's purpose; the voice is third person. (b) Any five of these:

- "As explained by Michael Pollan, a food detective and expert also known as the author of..." → Michael Pollan, author of The Omnivore's Dilemma, explains that...
- "considered healthy food due to the fact that" → considered healthy because
- "Even though there are organic grocery stores like Whole Foods seemingly everywhere" → Even though organic grocery stores like Whole Foods seem to be everywhere
- "to access healthy food due to lack of accessibility and affordability" (access and accessibility repeat the idea) → to find and afford healthy food
- "Gloria Howerton, a professor of the Geography Department at the University of Georgia and the author of..., mentions that" → Gloria Howerton, a geography professor at the University of Georgia, notes that
- "An area where there's a lack of fresh vegetables and fruits providers ... is known as a food desert." → A food desert is an area that lacks providers of fresh produce...
- "This paper will attempt to show why ... as well as discussing solutions that are in place to improve this situation." → Using West Oakland as a case study, this paper shows why... and discusses existing solutions.

My notes